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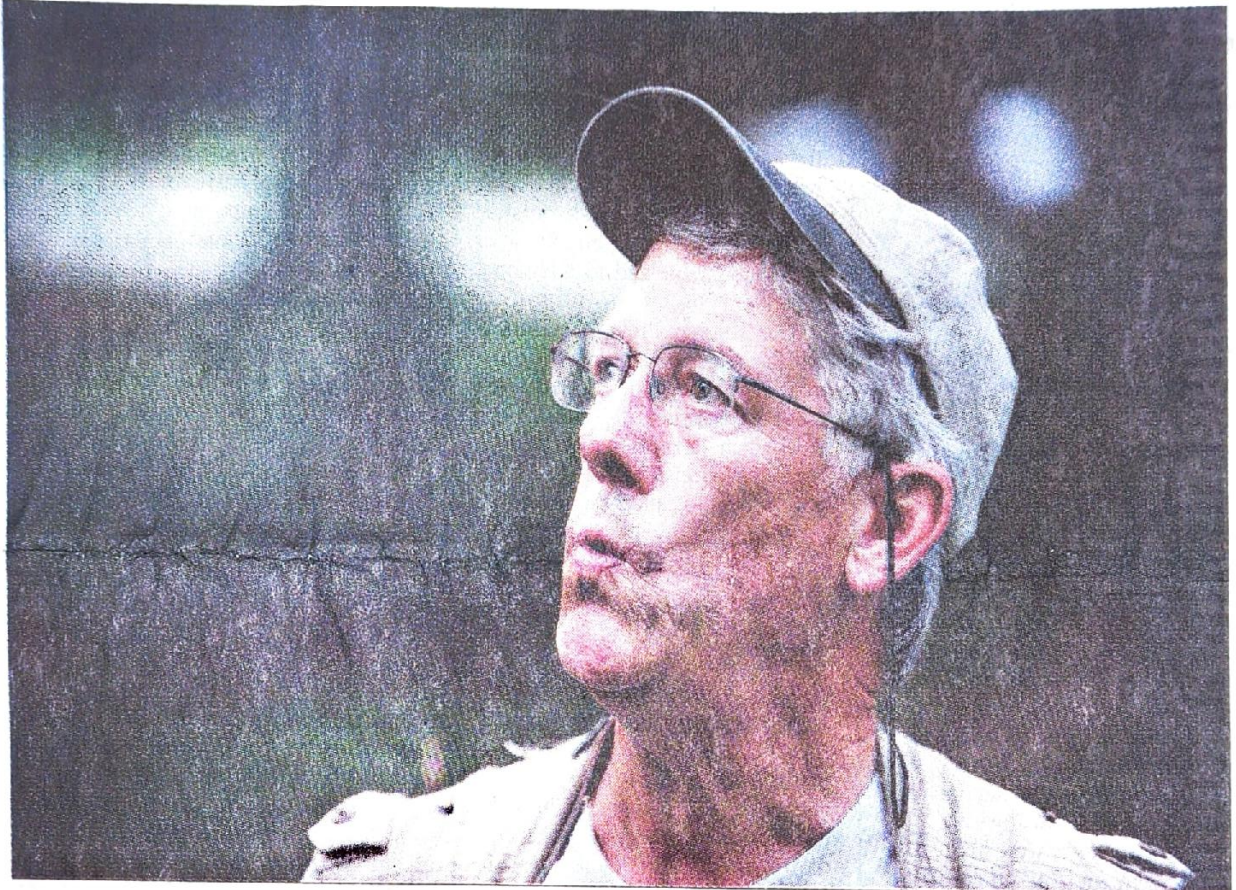
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Who's watching hoo?

The Owl Man helped Charlotte get to know its barred owls, but this week he'll make his last trip into the night



PHOTOS BY JEFF SINER - jsiner@charlotteobserver.com

Rob Bierregaard calls to barred owls Ned and Nellie in Myers Park. After 10 years studying Charlotte's barred owls, Bierregaard is leaving Charlotte for Philadelphia.

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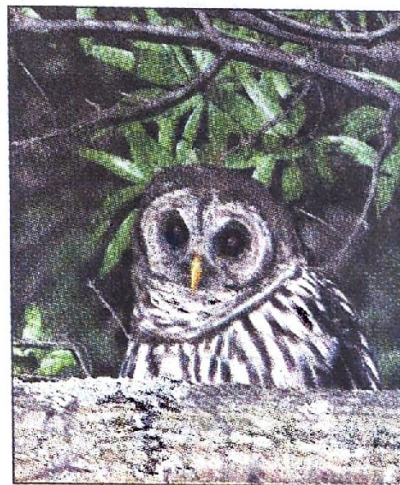
Hundreds of barred owls are living in the graceful willow oaks of Charlotte's older neighborhoods, but the man on the ground who tracked their habits for 10 years is leaving. Rob Bierregaard, an ornithologist who taught at UNC Charlotte, became such a presence in the owls' lives that many recognize his whistle.

A few years ago, he hung a nesting box high in a pine in Marsha Gaspari's front yard on Hermitage Road. She said Nellie, who raised two owlets there, knew Bierregaard so well she once swooped down at the sound of him locking his car. He had won her affection by bringing her mice to eat.

The Owl Man is moving to Philadelphia, where his wife took a job and where he will write up his research. He discovered that the urban trees of Myers Park, Eastover and Dilworth suit barred owls just as well as old-growth forests.

When he trolled for the birds at dusk, whole families tagged along. His departure, Gaspari says, is the city's loss.

About 300 owl couples live within 10 miles of uptown, and he named many of them: Billy the Kid and Paulita, King George and Wilhelmina, and Ned and Nellie, whose secrets he documented with a hidden camera in their nest.



A barred owl sits in a tree in the Edgehill Park area one night last week.

Online with Owl Man

To learn more about Rob Bierregaard and the owls: www.bioweb.uncc.edu/bierregaard/barred_owls.htm.

(You can recognize barred owls by their call. It sounds like: "Who cooks for you? Who cooks for you?")

OWLS UP CLOSE
Meet Nellie and Hermione. 10A

EYES ON CHARLOTTE'S OWLS

1 Bierregaard was out one night whistling for owls in Myers Park, and a skittish female flew down onto a nearby branch. He named her Nervous Nellie. In spring 2010, she discovered a nesting box he had placed in a tree on Hermitage Road. Nellie moved in, an owl named Ned courted her with mice and soon two owlets were born. ▼

2 Bierregaard catches owls the same way – by luring them with mice. This is Nellie. He put a radio transmitter on her back to track her movements, but she ripped it off. Ned still wears his. Bierregaard mounted a camera in their nesting box to see the food they brought their babies – mostly birds, mice and crayfish. ▼



COURTESY OF MARSHA GASPARI



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3 After six weeks, the babies began flapping their wings. They learned to fly first, then hunt. From high up in trees, they scan lawns and bushes below for prey, which makes the old neighborhoods perfect habitats. "You can't swing a dead rat in suburban Charlotte," Bierregaard said, "without hitting a barred owl." ▼

4 Bierregaard captured one of Nellie's owlets and the neighborhood named her Hermione, after the "Harry Potter" heroine. This year, Nellie nested near the Duke Mansion, and had triplets. In Edgehill Park at dusk, you might still see Nellie and Ned flying with their brood. But you won't see The Owl Man. He's flown this coop. ▼



COURTESY OF MARSHA GASPARI



COURTESY OF SARAH MCCONKEY